STRIDE

Get the athlete paid.
Show the brand what it bought.

For semi-professional athletes in niche sports, and the local businesses near their club

Jad Zoghaib MSc Business Plan, ESADE · Tutor: Ignacio Gallardo Albajar · October 2026

LIVE DEMO
stride-demo.onrender.com

WHY THIS

A national champion, and the sport has no way to pay him

TWO SPORTS, AT THE TOP OF BOTH

CROSSFIT	Champion of Lebanon
RUGBY LEAGUE	Among the best in the country

A friend I play rugby with, and one of the five athletes in the research behind this plan. He is not the exception in that group. He is what a niche sport looks like at the very top of it.

WHAT EITHER SPORT PAYS HIM

No rate

He is given things. Gear, product, the occasional paid post. None of it carries a price, a contract, or any reason to arrive a second time.

WHY I CAN SEE THIS AT ALL

Capped by the Lebanese national rugby team, so these are teammates rather than survey respondents. Four years of consulting built the model; the MSc and the build produced the product and its code.

One of the five athletes in the primary research. Full method and limitations in section 3.1.5.

People are not going to invest in social media and building followers if the return is minimal

One of the five. Rugby league players competing in Spain and Lebanon, and top-ranked Lebanese CrossFit athletes

WHAT THEY DO GET

- Gear and product
- The occasional paid post
- Prize money, sometimes

Real value, and not one euro of it carrying a rate, a contract, or any reason to expect it a second time. One of the five does have a sponsor, and it did not come through his sport.

THE INEQUITY IS FELT

Influencers producing far less demanding content earn more than competing athletes do

SO THEY STOP BUILDING AN AUDIENCE

Which suppresses the very supply the market is measured on

THE BUYER'S HALF

A local brand spends on instinct, and never finds out

“What did you get back, and how did you know?”

The question the sponsor discovery programme is built around. It is the one the whole analytics engine exists to answer, and today nobody below the professional tier owns an instrument that can.

WHO THE BUYER IS

Physiotherapy clinics, gyms, car dealers, restaurants and regional insurers within reach of an anchor athlete's club. The segment the agencies will not serve, and the one this model is built on.

CHOOSE

Two athletes, and nothing to compare them on but follower count, which is the one number that can be bought.

PRICE

No rate card and no benchmark anywhere in the segment. The fee is whatever was asked for.

VERIFY

The campaign ends, and nothing is known that was not known before it started.

THE MECHANISM

One missing layer explains both halves

IN A POPULAR SPORT

An agent introduces the athlete and vouches for the audience. Ten to twenty per cent, and the brand gets a number it can defend.

IN A NICHE SPORT

There is no agent. The athlete's alternative is not a worse deal, it is no deal. The brand's alternative is a guess.

AND THAT ABSENCE FEEDS ITSELF

01 No route from audience to income

›

02 So no reason to build an audience

›

03 So the market measures smaller than it is

An agent introduces, and an agent vouches. Below the professional tier neither function exists: no route to income on one side, no basis for a decision on the other. So the market is sized under the incentives that suppress it, and the honest error direction is understatement.

THE PRODUCT

Two engines, and each one is the other's reason to exist

ENGINE ONE

Monetisation

ATHLETE AND FAN

The athlete's own page, with paid fan tiers they price themselves. They keep 85% and pay nothing to be there. Self serve, with no sales touch per subscriber.

15% of fan revenue

ENGINE TWO

Analytics

SPONSOR

A campaign brief matched to athletes on measured audience evidence, every score decomposed into the arithmetic behind it, and delivery measured against what was projected.

10% of deal value, plus €99 to €999 a month

THE ATHLETE PAYS NOTHING

No monthly fee, ever, on either engine. The athlete earning €200 a month pays the same rate as the one earning €5,000, which a subscription would not have done. They are the supply, and supply is the constraint.

Stride financial model: Y7 net revenue of €3.01M, 48% from fans and 52% from the two sponsor streams.

WHY THEY ARE ONE COMPANY

Each engine produces the input the other cannot buy

01

Fans pay the athlete

Subscriptions give the athlete a reason to build an audience, and give us revenue from the first month.

›

02

The athlete connects their platforms

Monetising requires the connectors. Those same connectors are the measurement instrument.

›

03

The sponsor sees evidence

Measured reach, engagement and cost per thousand, per athlete, in place of a follower count.

›

04

Deals raise athlete income

Which brings the next athlete, and arrives with an audience that can now be measured.

AND FOUR RETURNS TO ONE

WHY NEITHER HALF STANDS ALONE

A creator platform has no reason to measure an audience. A sponsorship data company has no relationship with the athlete, so it cannot get the measurements. Both halves are required, and that is the architecture rather than a roadmap.

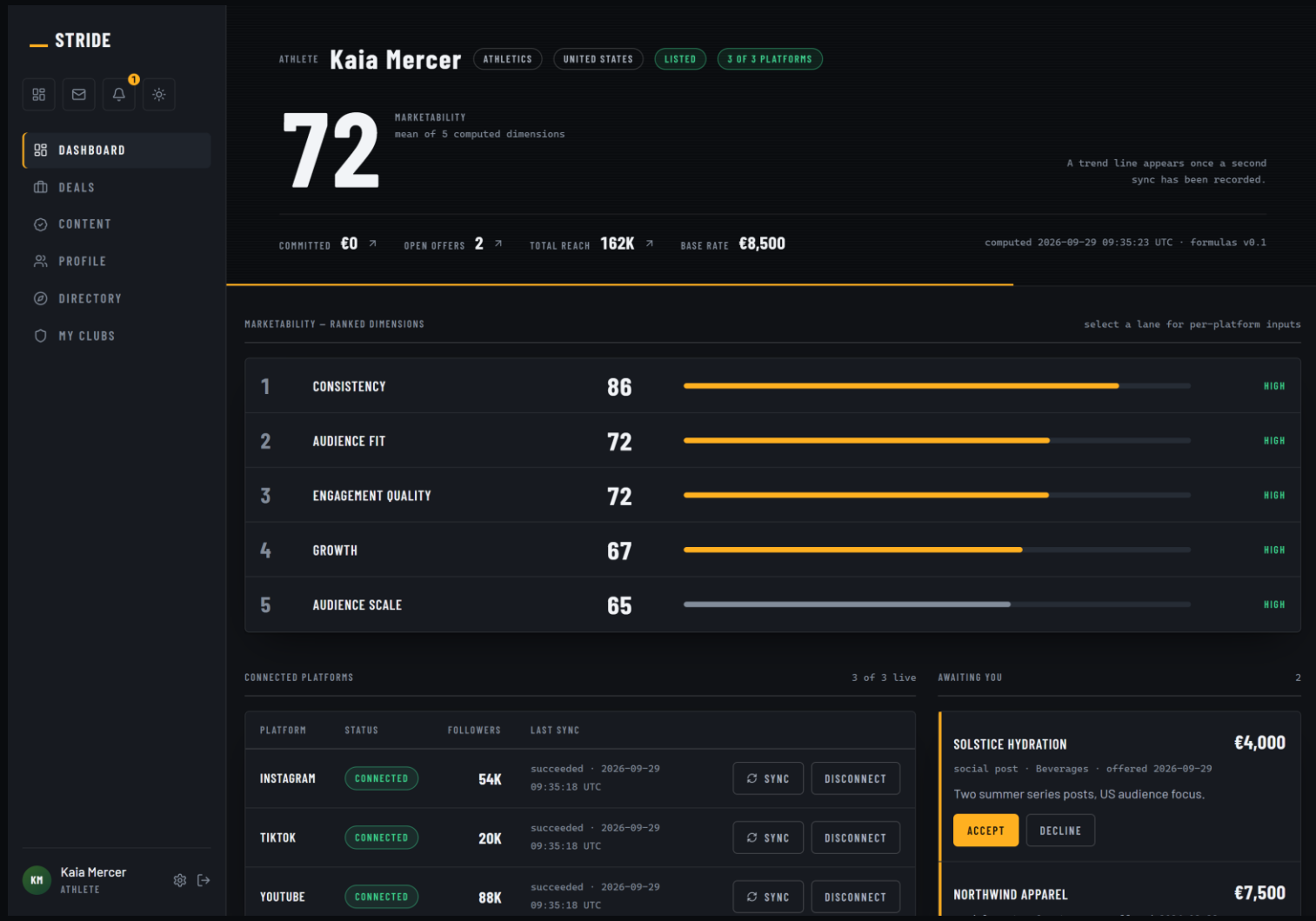
Fan revenue funds the years in which the data accrues. By the time the analytics are worth selling, someone else has already paid to build them.

NOT A MOCKUP

It is built, deployed, and you can open it now

- Admission gate with human review
- Versioned marketability scoring
- Explainable campaign matching
- Offers, deals, delivery measurement
- Audit log and a resilience drill
- Tests on two databases in CI

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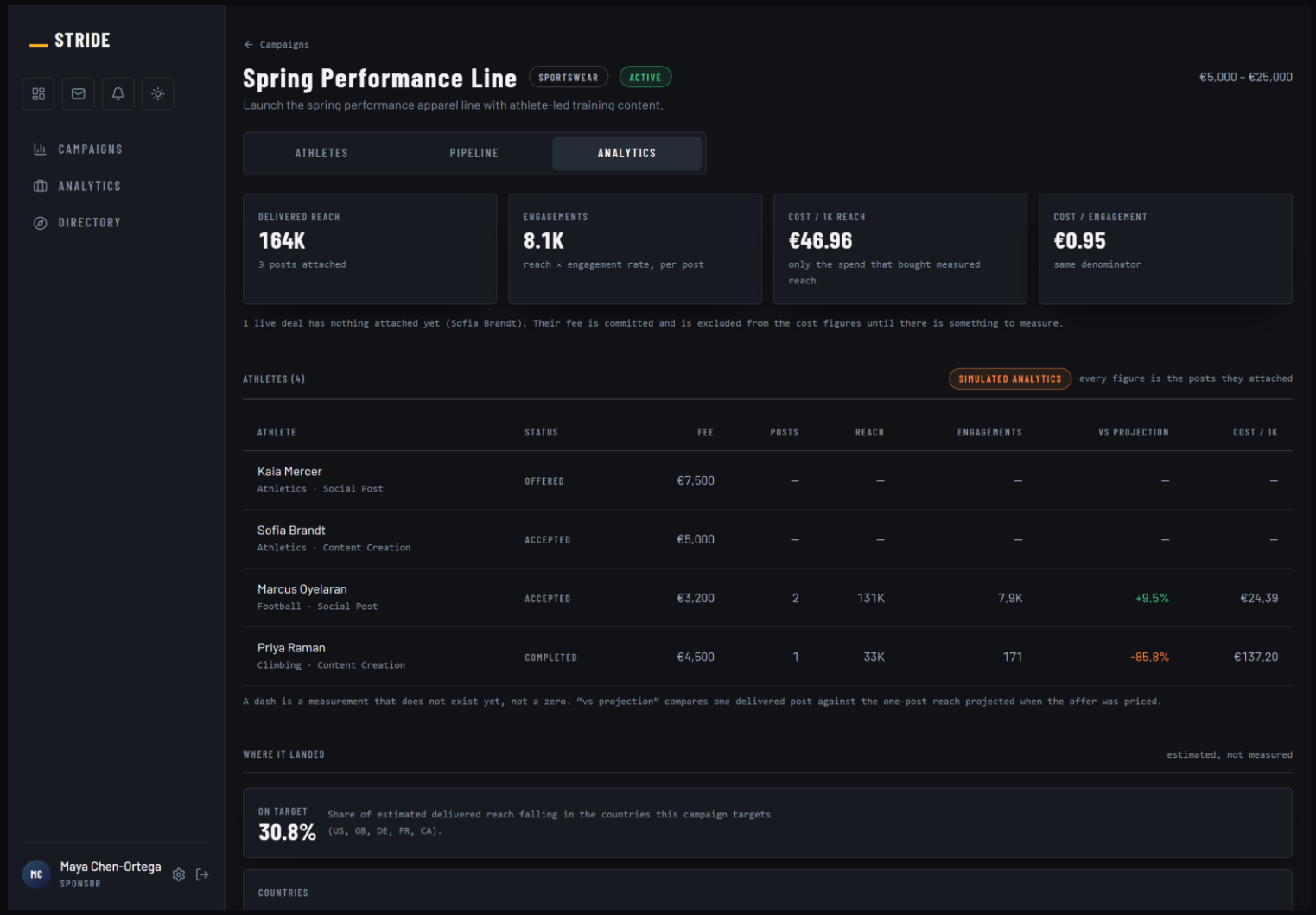


THE SECOND ENGINE, RUNNING

And this is what replaces the instinct

- Delivered reach and engagements, per athlete
- Cost per thousand reached, cost per engagement
- Delivered against what was projected when priced
- Share of reach landing in the targeted countries
- Every match score decomposed to its arithmetic
- A dash where nothing is measured. Never a zero

The arithmetic is shown because a brand that cannot audit the number will not spend against it a second time. The red figure on that screen is a deal that underdelivered, and the product says so.



PRIMARY RESEARCH

The research changed the product, which is the point of doing it

> Open registration to everyone, but build a filtering mechanism so that not anyone can register as an athlete.

Íñigo Cristóbal Losada, AI Lead at olympics.com, after eleven years at Olympic Broadcasting Services, where he was Broadcaster Services Manager through Tokyo 2020 and Beijing 2022.

WHAT IT CHANGED

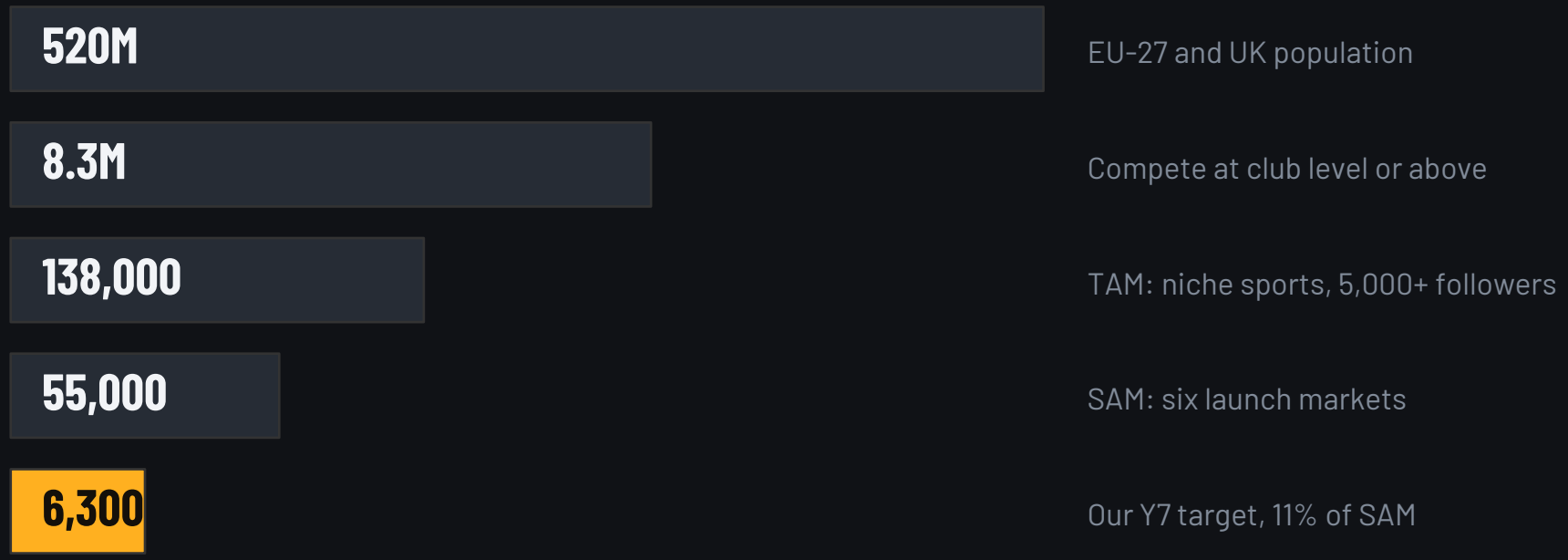
I had pitched it to him as a product for the IOC, open only to Olympic athletes. He rejected that framing outright.

The admission gate exists because of that conversation. It is not a feature that was designed and then justified.

It also settled market entry. An IOC-only product inherits the IOC's athletes: elite, represented, already monetised. The segment with the actual problem sits below that tier.

HOW BIG, BOTTOM UP

A segment nobody measures is a segment nobody has sized a product for



EUROPEAN SPORT SPONSORSHIP

€24.79bn

Growing 5.9% a year

SPAIN, THE FASTEST MAJOR MARKET

+14%

Ahead of the UK and France

None of that top-down figure breaks below the professional tier. There is no published number for sponsorship of individual athletes, so the plan does not divide it by anything. The bottom-up funnel exists because the measured market stops exactly where ours starts.

European Sponsorship Association, 2025, via Statista. Funnel: Eurostat, Eurobarometer 525, and the plan's own Sport Opportunity Index.

THE WEDGE

We start where there is no incumbent, because that is also where the economics are best

NICHE SPORTS

€16

To acquire one athlete in Y1

48%

Of them monetise by Y7

POPULAR SPORTS

€40

To acquire one athlete in Y1

30%

Of them monetise by Y7

Cheaper to acquire, and a larger share of them earn. A professional already has an agent and would not use this, so nobody is fighting us for a trail runner with 25,000 followers and an inbox of unanswered brand DMs. What we learn there generalises upward. Football does not generalise downward.

WHY THE TWO SIDES FIT

A niche athlete's audience is concentrated where they train and compete. That concentration is worth little to a national advertiser, and it is exactly what the clinic two streets from the club is trying to buy and has no other way of buying. The same choice makes supply cheap and demand local.

Stride financial model, segment assumptions. Acquisition cost rises over the plan as the mix shifts toward popular sports.

FOUR COMPANIES TRIED THIS BEFORE US

Two built the marketplace, two built the data. Nobody built both

COMPANY	WHAT IT IS	AGE	PEOPLE	RAISED	WHERE IT GOT TO
Sponsoo	Marketplace, same model	11 yrs	13	€2.17M	Total equity zero
OpenSponsorship	Marketplace, same model	12 yrs	23	€7.6M	Still private
Hookit	Sponsorship data	18 yrs	47	€21.5M	Sold
SponsorUnited	Sponsorship data, enterprise	9 yrs	355	€38.8M	A different business

The one that got large sells data to agencies and rights holders, and never executes a deal. 355 people is what enterprise sales costs, and it is the reason nobody runs this motion down at a €2,000 sponsorship.

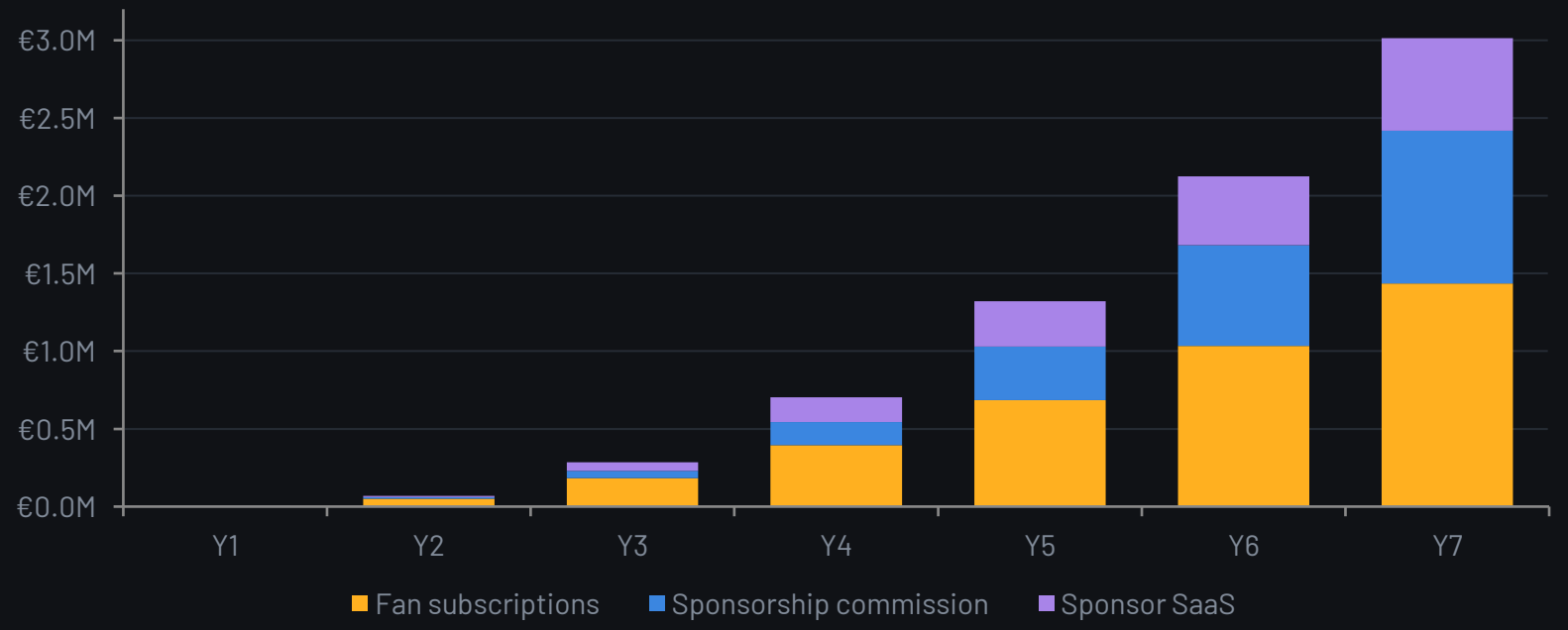
THE SECOND PAYER

Fan subscriptions are 48% of our Y7 revenue, and none of these four has that stream at all. If it works, the economics are not Sponsoo's. If it does not, they are, and this is Sponsoo with eleven fewer years of relationships. The plan prices both cases.

PitchBook company profiles, retrieved 1 October 2026, reported in euros.

REVENUE MODEL

The business changes shape as it grows



Y2

75%

of revenue is fan subscriptions, the year the thesis is tested

Y7

48%

still fan, with sponsorship and SaaS compounding behind it

€3.01M total at Y7

Stride financial model. Y1 to Y7, net revenue after the athlete's share.

GO TO MARKET

Year one, concretely

250

ATHLETES

recruited from 1,250 applications, in two or three niche Spanish sports

20

SPONSOR CONVERSATIONS

which are the first sales as much as the research, closing about 15 deals

1

SALARY

mine, plus a named athlete partner on 5% equity rather than cash

€113k

OF CASH

two thirds of it available as a non-dilutive ENISA loan

THE SEQUENCE IS THE OPPOSITE OF THE OBVIOUS ONE

Build the payment rail and sponsorship billing first, and the fan tier last. Commission is invoiced against a signed deal: it needs no content moderation, no minors safeguarding and no media egress, so it is the cheapest of the three to build and the only one that earns inside the first year.

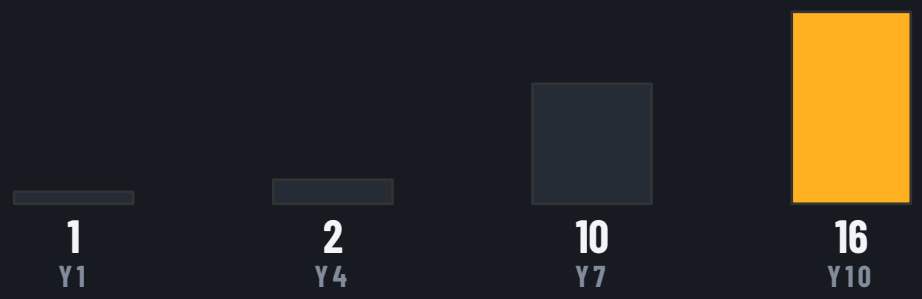
OPERATIONS AND PEOPLE

One human step in the chain, and a team sized to what I can actually run

WHAT IS SUBCONTRACTED

Stripe Connect	Payments, KYC and payouts in 30+ countries
AWS	Compute, database and media processing
Zero-egress CDN	Media delivery, the cost that decides viability

HEADCOUNT



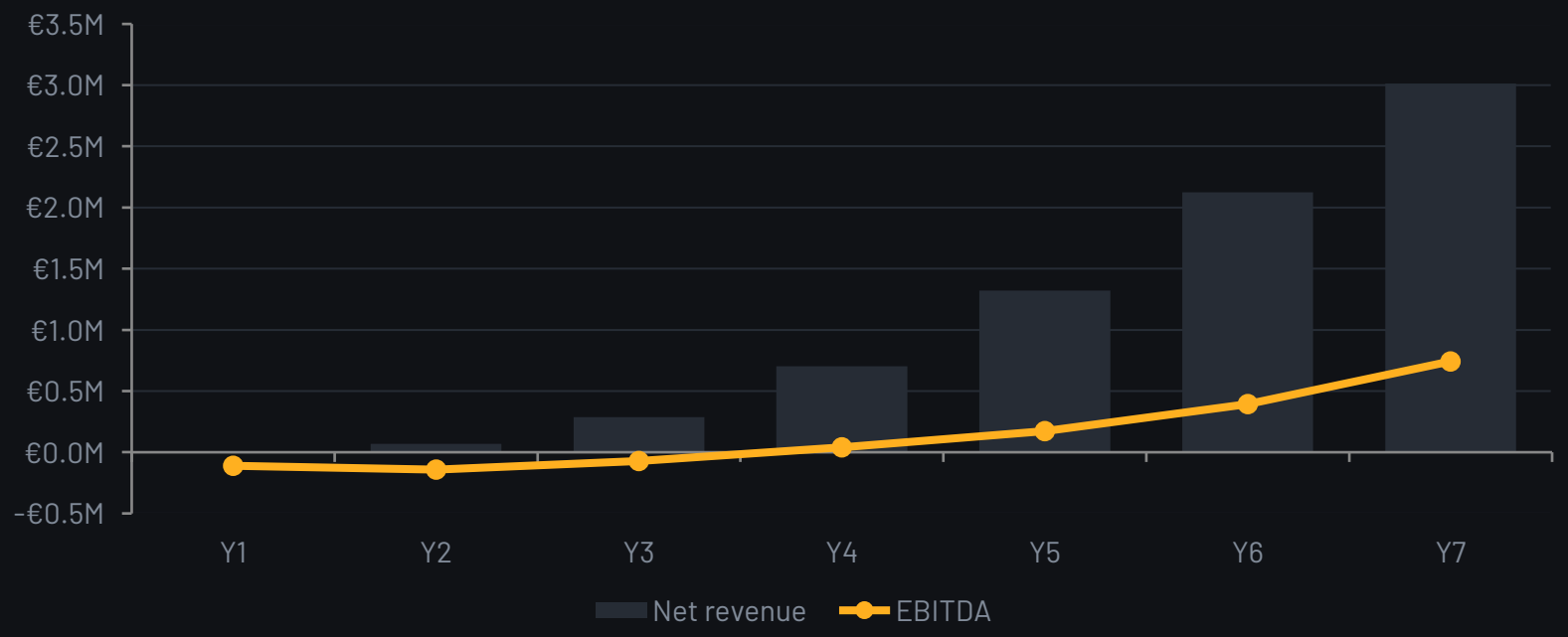
The only human step in the value chain is admission review, and it scales with applications rather than with transactions. That is why sixteen people can run this. Sponsoo took eleven years to reach thirteen, so the comparison is deliberate rather than optimistic.

THE ASSUMPTION I AM MOST EXPOSED ON

€301k of revenue per employee at Y7, against a private B2B SaaS median of €135k. If I am wrong, the first thing to give is headcount, which means slower growth rather than a cash crisis.

FINANCIAL PLAN

Loss-making for four years, and the losses are small



EBITDA POSITIVE

Y4

CASH POSITIVE

Y5

Y7 EBITDA MARGIN

24.7%

Y10 NET REVENUE

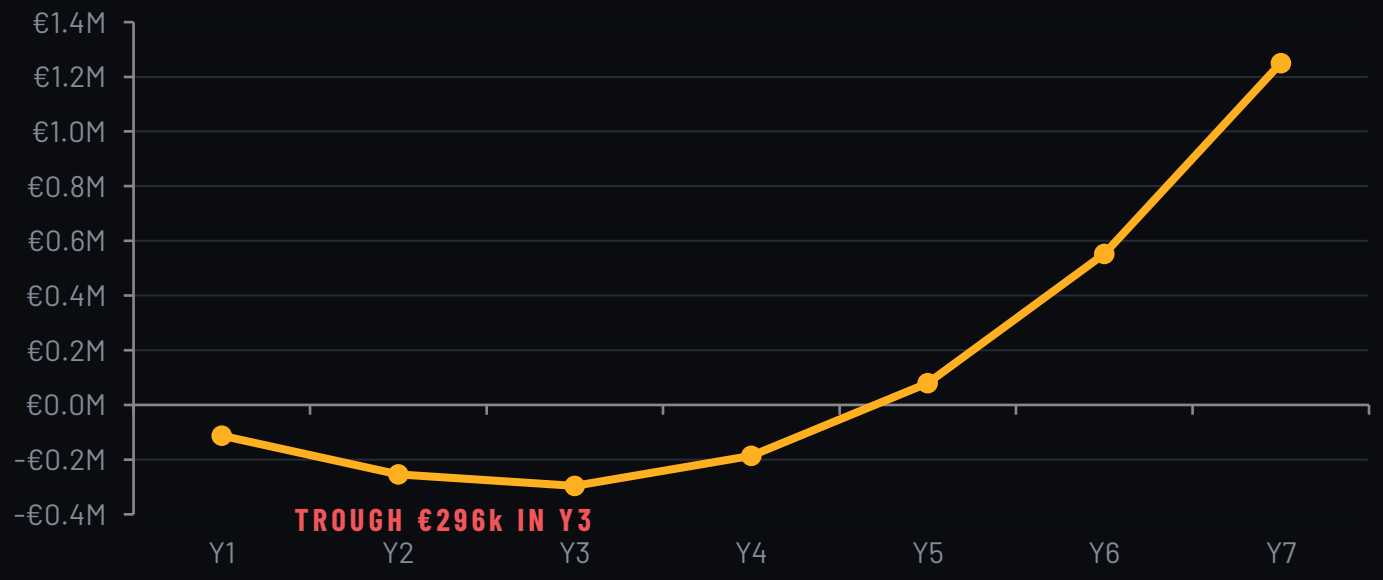
€5.25M

Gross margin climbs from 63% to 70%, not the SaaS 80%, because the payment rail is real.

THE ASK

€150k at €1.8M pre-money

The first of two tranches, and the round that clears the worst point in the cash curve



TOTAL REQUIREMENT
€414k
the €296k trough plus a 40% buffer

NOW
€150k
equity, which also unlocks €75k of non-dilutive ENISA debt

IN Y2
€250k
priced against three months of real subscription revenue, not a promise

Staging it costs about two points of equity and buys the right to price the second tranche on evidence. A plan whose survival does not depend on the next round arriving on schedule is a stronger one to raise against.

ONE ASSUMPTION CARRIES THIS PLAN

Will fans of a semi-professional athlete actually pay?

No interview answers it and no amount of further market sizing can. Only three months of real subscription revenue from one anchor athlete settles it, and that is exactly what the pre-seed buys.

TESTED FOR

€80k and one year

rather than €2.6M and four

IF IT FAILS

A smaller marketplace

viable, but a different company

EVERYTHING ELSE

Already done

built, deployed and demonstrable

STRIDE

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BACKUP

Held for questions

The four steps, the matching arithmetic, how we differ from the data companies, pricing, scenarios, risk, valuation and the admission gate.

BACKUP, MECHANICS

Four steps, and a rule that holds all four together

How an athlete gets in, gets scored, gets matched and gets paid.

01
APPLY

The athlete connects their platforms and applies. Proof is checked automatically, then a person decides. A club can nominate a whole roster as a second route.

02
SCORE

Marketability is the mean of five computed dimensions, each traceable to the posts behind it, and every score version is kept.

03
MATCH

A sponsor briefs a campaign, and the match is scored on eight weighted components, each one decomposed: audience fit 72 × 32% = 23.1.

04
DEAL

Offer, acceptance, delivery measured against what was projected. An unmeasured campaign reads as unmeasured, never as zero.

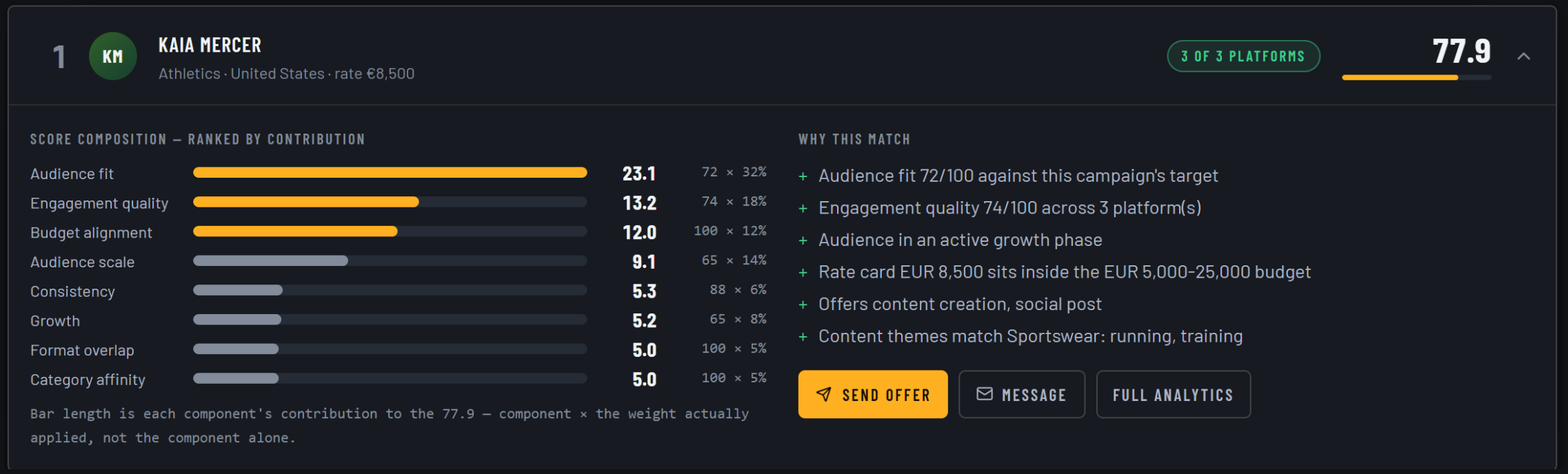
NOTHING SELF-VERIFIES

A club scoring above the verification bar still waits for a human. A rejected proof cannot be cleared by re-submitting the form. That is what a sponsor is actually buying.

BACKUP, THE MATCHING ENGINE

A ranked athlete, opened on the arithmetic that ranked them

Eight weighted components. Bar length is the contribution to the total, not the component alone.



THE WEIGHTS ARE HAND SET

A transparent weighted sum. Learned weights come once there are outcomes, and must beat this.

COVERAGE TRAVELS WITH THE SCORE

Three of three platforms, or one of three. A thin score is marked thin, not quietly averaged.

IT READS IN PLAIN LANGUAGE TOO

Because the person approving the spend is rarely the person running the campaign.

Ranked matches for a live campaign, captured from the running application.

BACKUP, THE COMPARABLE THAT GOT LARGE

They sell what the market did. We measure what your money did

Slide 13 split the set two and two. This is what the split means to a brand with €2,000 to spend.

	Sponsoo, OpenSponsorship THE MARKETPLACES	Hookit, SponsorUnited THE DATA COMPANIES	Stride BOTH HALVES, ONE LOOP
CHOOSE	Browse a roster. Follower counts, self reported	Market intelligence: who sponsors whom, at scale	Ranked against your brief, every score decomposed
PRICE	You negotiate. No benchmark	A media value estimate for a property	A reach projection attached to the offer itself
VERIFY	Screenshots from the athlete	What the market did, from public posts	Delivered against that projection, per athlete
THE DATA	The athlete's own claim	Scraped, public, third party	The connector the athlete linked to get paid
THE BUYER	Brands of any size, thin support	Rights holders, agencies, enterprise seats	The clinic, the gym, the dealer

WHY THEY CANNOT FOLLOW

Delivery is measured against a projection written onto the deal at the moment the offer is made. A company that was not in the transaction never saw the promise, so it has nothing to reconcile against. That is a position, not a feature.

Plan section 3.2.2 on the competitive set and section 4.6 on the buyer. Neither data company executes a deal.

BACKUP, PRICING

15% sits between the only two published rates in the market

Both ends of the corridor are real competitor economics, derived from filed accounts.

PATREON

10%

all-in, on filed accounts

STRIDE

15%

flat, and no monthly athlete fee

ONLYFANS

20%

and agencies take 20 to 50% on top

At 15% we undercut the nearest comparable for any athlete earning under €1,380 a month, which is the entire long tail we are built for. The decision forfeits €0.5M of Y7 revenue against a 20% take, and buys a pricing argument that survives contact with the exact athlete we target.

Patreon and OnlyFans published terms and filed accounts; agency rates from published commission guides.

BACKUP, SCENARIOS

The plan survives its own pessimistic case

Each case re-runs the whole model on changed drivers rather than adjusting the base result.

CASE	WHAT CHANGES	Y7 REVENUE	Y7 EBITDA	CAPITAL NEED	PROFIT FROM
Pessimistic	Fans/athlete –30%, monetise –25%, churn at benchmark	**€2.34M**	**€399k**	**€541k**	**Y5**
Base	As modelled	**€3.01M**	**€743k**	**€414k**	**Y4**
Optimistic	Fans/athlete +25%, monetise +20%	**€3.59M**	**€1.04M**	**€347k**	**Y4**

Even the pessimistic case breaks even, one year later and on €541k instead of €414k. The downside here is a slower, smaller company rather than a failed one, and that is the property the staged raise is designed to protect.

Stride financial model, scenario table.

BACKUP, RISK

Eleven risks scored, and one of them is the thesis

Probability × impact, both on a 1 to 5 scale. Nothing is rated more likely than 3.

R1	Fans do not pay for niche-athlete content	3 × 5 = 15	Three months of real revenue from one anchor athlete, before the second tranche
R2	Churn is at benchmark, not 45% better	3 × 4 = 12	Measure early, on one athlete, before the extension. The model understates this
R3	Athlete acquisition slower than modelled	3 × 4 = 12	Club and federation channels are multiplicative: one conversation is 20 to 40 athletes

A risk map that is evenly scattered has not identified which risk is the real one. R1 is the thesis, and the entire financing structure exists to buy it down cheaply.

BACKUP, VALUATION

Where the €1.8M pre-money comes from

Two methods that disagree, and the disagreement is the honest part.

DCF ENTERPRISE VALUE

€1.23M

25% WACC, 3% terminal growth. Below the pre-money, which is normal for a pre-revenue venture.

COMPARABLE SET

€1.8M

Benchmarked against Sponsoo and OpenSponsorship, the two companies running the same model.

FOUNDER AND TEAM HOLD

65.2%

After both tranches, the optional growth round and a fully topped 10% ESOP.

PRE-SEED

€150k at €1.8M

87.3%

EXTENSION

€250k at €3.5M

81.5%

GROWTH, OPTIONAL

€1.5M at €12M

72.4%

AFTER ESOP

10% pool

65.2%

Founder stake retained through each round

Stride financial model: DCF, comparable transactions from PitchBook, and the dilution waterfall.

BACKUP, THE GATE

What the admission gate actually costs to run

The one human step in the chain, priced from the policy itself rather than assumed.

30.5%

ADMISSION RATE BY Y7

rising from 20% in Y1 as the funnel improves, which makes it a filter rather than a formality

4 min

MEDIAN MANUAL REVIEW

priced at the same loaded salary the people line uses

0.06 FTE

REVIEWER LOAD AT Y10

at 8,500 athletes. Verification is not a money problem at this scale

< 48 h

SERVICE LEVEL

the reason to automate is latency, not cost: a queued athlete is not earning

A club nomination brings a roster of 20 to 40 athletes with the verification problem already solved, and club-nominated applicants are admitted at 45% against 20% direct. That is the channel the growth plan opens at Y3.